



Aircraft carrier

The USS *Enterprise*, here loaded with helicopters and planes during the evacuation of Saigon in April 1975, was used to launch airstrikes at various points in the war.

Intercepting supply lines

One of the Navy's most important roles was disrupting the so-called Sihanouk Trail—the North Vietnamese supply route into South Vietnam via the port of Sihanoukville in Cambodia. Weapons and supplies were smuggled on sampans and fishing trawlers. Initially, the Republic of Vietnam Navy addressed such smuggling, but its efforts were ineffective and prone to corruption. In 1965, the US Navy and Coast Guard launched Operation Market Time to intercept and search thousands of vessels. The Brown Water Navy, which patrolled inland waterways, performed a similar function in the Mekong Delta and the Ca Mau Peninsula, where transportation routes largely consisted of rivers and canals.

70,000 The number of junks, sampans, and fishing boats, inspected by the Coastal Surveillance Force in 1966–67.

Search-and-destroy

The Brown Water Navy also conducted search-and-destroy missions against the Viet Cong, which had long operated in areas that infantry equipped with tanks and heavy artillery could not reach. In 1965, the Seventh Fleet's River Patrol Force launched Operation Game Warden, an attack on Viet Cong capabilities in the Mekong Delta. Consisting of small patrol